supposed to do it five times a day." Risking further offense, I ask if he wants her to wear the hijab. She shakes her head no. They are both modern Indian Muslims, far from the world of male dominance in places like Saudi Arabia or Afghanistan, or more fundamentalist forms of Islam. Yet the sting of feeling that she has no choice in the most important decision of her life makes her, like Sita, feel helpless. Can she love him, I ask? "I will make myself love him" is her response. I subsequently hear that she has had her first child, though I can't discover if she kept working in media.

It doesn't seem like that should be the case for an urban, educated female, given the prominence of many women today. Today's India is filled with images of powerful women, from politicians to movie stars. There seems to be little overt prejudice against female politicians in a country that was ruled by Indira Gandhi for nearly twenty years. The Congress Party, political home of India's first prime minister, Jawaharlal Nehru, and base for the Gandhi dynasty, was long dominated by Sonia Gandhi, the Italian-born widow of Indira's son, former prime minister Rajiv Gandhi, after his assassination in 1991. Sonia, despite her checkered political success, was the party president, controlling nearly every aspect of party management, and remains its parliamentary chairperson.

Not all of India's female leaders were born in the purple, however. Three of the country's most important states, including Chennai's Tamil Nadu, are now or recently have been run by elected female chief ministers from among the commoners. India's most populous state, Uttar Pradesh, with a population of nearly 180 million, was run four times by Kumari Mayawati, who built a minicult of personality around herself during her terms starting in 1995 and ending most recently in 2012. A trip through Lucknow, Uttar Pradesh's capital, during Mayawati's last chief ministership revealed massive billboards at every intersection with her image and a list of her accomplishments in office, while huge, pharaonic-like structures built on her orders dot the city. The fact that she is a Dalit, from the caste once known as "untouchable," and the first elected female Dalit chief minister, only